Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

The Washington Post

SU V1 V2 V3 V4

Rain, snow shower 42/35 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 41/26 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, DECEMBER 20, 2024 · $3

Number of deported hits highest in a decade

ICE report shows pattern of growing enforcement by Biden administration

BY NICK MIROFF AND MARIA SACCHETTI

U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement deported 271,484 immigrants to nearly 200 countries last fiscal year, the highest tally in a decade, according to the agency's annual report published Thursday.

Most deportees had crossed the U.S. southern border illegally, part of a record number of people fleeing authoritarian regimes, poverty and economic collapse in the Western Hemisphere after the pandemic. The ICE report covered enforcement operations from Oct. 1, 2023, to Sept. 30.

The report is ICE's final accounting of immigration enforcement under the Biden administration before President-elect Donald Trump takes office on Jan. 20. Trump has promised to immediately launch the largest deportation campaign in American history, though he has offered few or conflicting details about how he would manage it. Staffing levels of immigration enforcement officers have been stagnant for years.

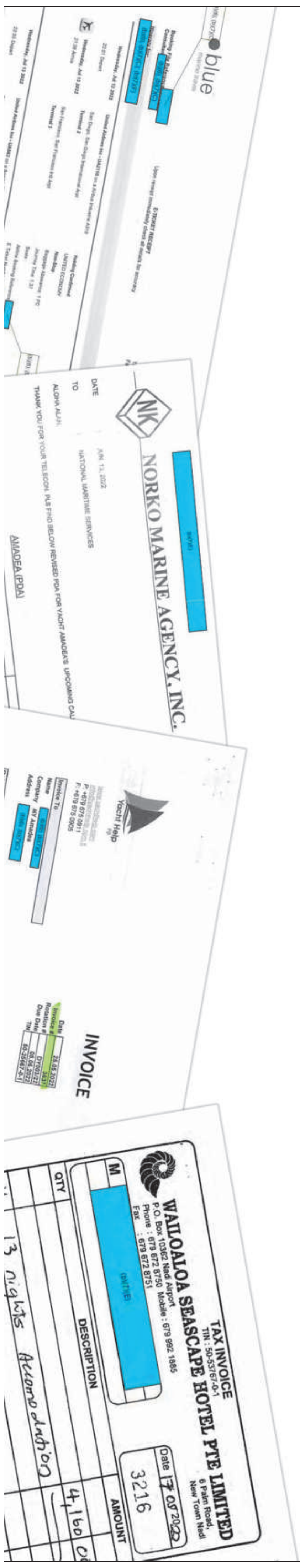
"Our agency is chronically underfunded, but our workforce is adaptable, resilient and agile, and they set the bar high within the federal government," said ICE's top official Patrick J. Lechleitner, in a statement. "ICE is an apolitical agency, and one thing I can tell you about our workforce is that they're here to investigate crimes and enforce the laws Congress sets forth."

Biden took office in 2021 pledging to pause deportations, and he sent Congress a bill that would have allowed most of the 11 million undocumented immigrants in the country to get on paths to citizenship. But surging border crossings derailed his plans, and Biden officials ended up expanding rather than reducing detention and deportations.

Illegal border crossings have plunged since Biden implemented new rules last summer that

SEE REPORT ON A4

Capacity: Detention firms offered beds to ICE this year, suit shows. A4



THE MONEY WAR

THE U.S. SEIZED A RUSSIAN YACHT. YOU'RE PAYING FOR IT.

Documents show taxpayers footed the bill for fuel, phones, even toilet brushes

BY JEFF STEIN, STEPHANIE HAYS, NATE JONES AND FEDERICA COCCO

On June 2, 2022, the United States government spent $12,458 to scrub the hull of a Russian oligarch's superyacht.

Six days later, U.S. taxpayers spent $52,717.08 primarily on meat, fish, dairy, bread, spices and other groceries for the 30 crew members of the luxury vessel, named the Amadea.

Five days later, taxpayers shelled out an additional $277,200 on the Amadea — this time to put 52,800 gallons of fuel in the six-deck yacht ahead of its voyage from Fiji to San Diego, where it's been docked on America's dime for most of the past two years.

In response to a Freedom of Information Act lawsuit filed by The Washington Post, the Justice Department divulged more than 1,300 pages of records showing how the government has maintained the $325 million Russian superyacht since it was seized in Fiji in May 2022.

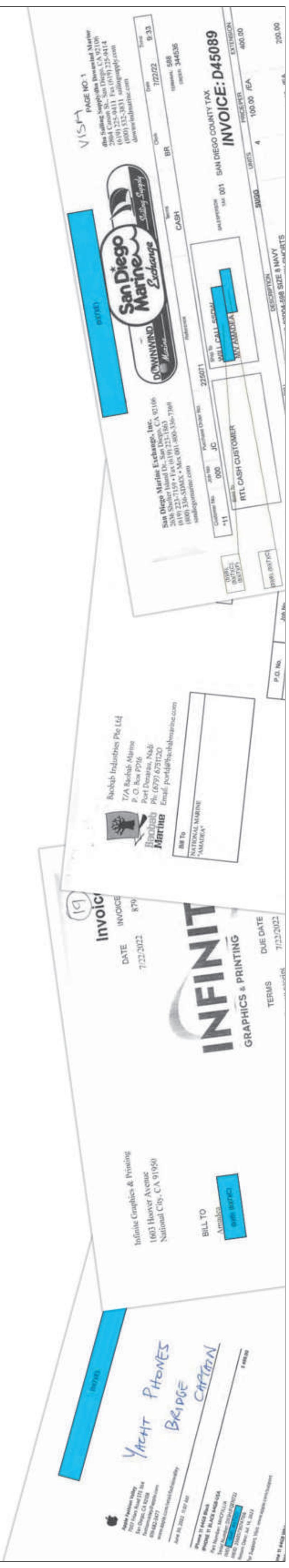
At the time, the yacht's capture was touted as a major prize in President Joe Biden's economic war against Vladimir Putin's invasion of Ukraine. The United States claimed the yacht was owned by Russian gold magnate Suleyman Kerimov — sanctioned since 2018 as part of a broader U.S. campaign against Putin's allies — and pushed for its quick sale.

The proceeds were supposed to be transferred to Ukraine for its defense. But the Amadea has thus far produced no funds for Ukraine — and its capture came with a surprising drawback: tens of millions of dollars in maintenance costs billed to U.S. taxpayers.

Until now, those costs have been largely hidden from public view. But records obtained by The Post, coupled with federal court filings, indicate that the United States has spent roughly $30 million in maintaining the Amadea since it was seized — a figure a Justice Department spokeswoman later confirmed.

The counterintuitive outcome underscores the shortcomings of the U.S. push to seize and sell the assets of Russian oligarchs. That effort has yielded just

SEE SANCTIONS ON A10



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Another funding bill fails in House

SHUTDOWN LOOMS EARLY SATURDAY

Speaker's Trump-backed plan falls far short in vote

BY JACOB BOGAGE AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

The federal government moved closer to a weekend shutdown Thursday, after the House overwhelmingly voted down Speaker Mike Johnson's new plan to extend the deadline despite support from President-elect Donald Trump and his billionaire adviser Elon Musk.

The GOP proposal would have extended federal operations into mid-March, sent more than $100 billion to natural-disaster survivors and suspended the country's borrowing limit for two years. But it needed the support of two-thirds of the House to pass, and it went down by a 235-174 vote, with one member voting present. It wasn't clear Thursday night what the next move will be.

Johnson spent the day negotiating the new plan with his fellow Republicans, after Trump and Musk rallied the GOP on Wednesday against a bipartisan proposal that Johnson had

SEE SHUTDOWN ON A6

Mike Johnson: To remain speaker, he must keep Trump on board. **A7**

Debt ceiling: Lawmakers stunned by Trump's push to repeal limit. **A8**

RFK Stadium: D.C. control is in limbo after failed spending bill. **B1**

Musk flexes influence in wrangling over budget

Billionaire's outsize role alarms watchdog groups, Democrats, academics

This article is by Cat Zakrzewski, Jacqueline Alemany, Marianne LeVine, Liz Goodwin and Colby Itkowitz

Elon Musk has never been elected to office. President-elect Donald Trump has not tapped him to serve in any role inside the government. Until the July assassination attempt, he never even publicly supported Trump.

But this week, critics of the world's richest man say he attained a new title: "shadow president" of the United States.

In a matter of hours on Wednesday, Musk wielded his powerful X account to pressure House Republicans to torpedo a spending bill that would have kept the federal government open for three months.

Musk's rapid-fire messages — which included numerous false claims about the contents of the spending bill — ricocheted through Washington, where some lawmakers reported their phone lines were ringing all day with calls from constituents who

SEE MUSK ON A6

Tariff-wary consumers go on a spree that could cost us all

Big-ticket purchases are up ahead of Trump's 2nd term, which economists say could stoke inflation

BY ABHA BHATTARAI AND JACLYN PEISER

Americans are scrambling to stock up on cars, appliances and other big-ticket imports in anticipation of new Trump administration tariffs — a spending spree that could reignite the very inflation buyers are hoping to avoid.

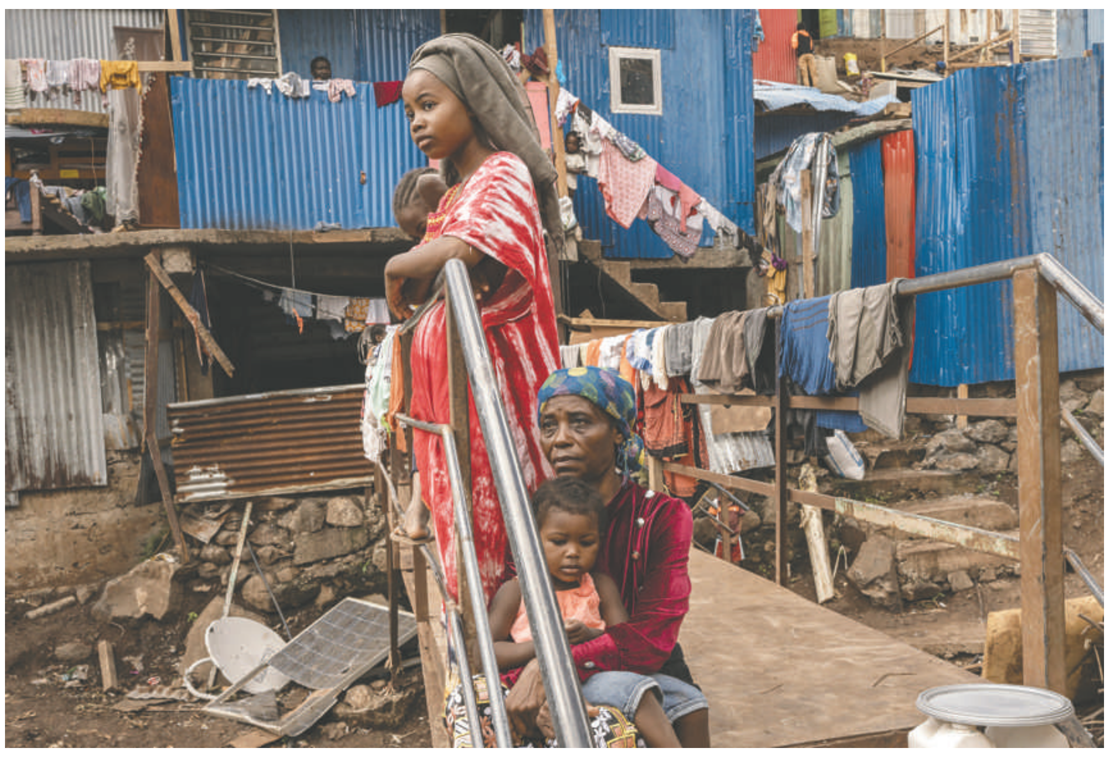
President-elect Donald Trump has vowed to enact widespread tariffs as soon as he takes office in January, a move that economists say could lift prices for just about every type of import, including food, cars, computers and gas. Although Trump has offered few specifics, he has said his planned policies would take aim at America's three largest trading partners, with 60 percent tariffs on all Chinese imports and 25 percent tariffs on goods from Mexico and Canada.

There are signs that price-sensitive households and businesses already are shifting their spending behavior to guard against further cost increases. New data this week showed that Americans spent $3.6 billion more on vehicles and auto parts in November than they did the month before — a notable bump in an otherwise lackluster retail sales reading. Spending on electronics and appliances also rose last month, which economists attributed to a combination of Hurricane Helene-related repairs and households preparing for new tariffs.

And although it's not clear whether that increased demand is driving higher prices just yet, economists say it's notable that both appliances and new vehicles got costlier in November even as inflation eased in other areas.

"It is clear that people are

SEE INFLATION ON A2



ADRIENNE SURPRENANT/AP

'There is nowhere to go'

Women and children rest on a footbridge over a stream filled with debris in the Kaweni slum in the French territory of Mayotte on Thursday, several days after Cyclone Chido tore through the Indian Ocean archipelago, leaving entire neighborhoods flattened and hundreds feared dead. **Story, A12**

IN THE NEWS

Civil service Federal workers began preparing for a showdown over the Trump administration's vow to slash their ranks. A3

Trump trial in Georgia An appellate court disqualified Fulton County District Attorney Fani T. Willis from prosecuting the president-elect on criminal racketeering charges. A9

THE NATION

The suspect in a CEO's shooting faces federal charges that include murder and stalking. A3

After 12 delays in sentencing, a former police chief got 25 years for trafficking a teen. A9

THE WORLD

European allies are weighing deploying troops to Ukraine in the event of a ceasefire. A13

Fifty-one men were convicted of rape in a trial in France that has shocked the world. A14

THE ECONOMY

The White House is drafting a plan to encourage construction of data centers on federal lands to power AI. A15

The Teamsters held strikes at seven Amazon warehouses, disrupting the e-commerce giant's operations during the Christmas season. A16

THE REGION

A former sheriff in Culpeper County, Va., was found guilty of selling deputy credentials for bribes ranging from $5,000 to $25,000. B1

Two students were charged and in-person classes canceled because of fights at Alexandria City High School. B1

STYLE

It's the end of an era for the red-state Democrat, as three senators pack up their offices on Capitol Hill. C1

WEEKEND

New Year's Eve events for all kinds, whether you'll stay up into the wee hours or be home before the ball drops.